

Teaching Discourse and Reproducing Culture: A Critique of Research and Pedagogy in Professional and Non-Academic Writing

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When Lester Faigley organized contemporary theory about the composing process into the expressive, the cognitive, and the social in "Competing Theories of the Process," he described "the 'social view' of writing as a group of theories that include poststructuralist theories of language, the sociology of science, ethnography, and Marxism" (535). In doing so, he marked out the theoretical position that supports most research in professional and non-academic writing. But Faigley's taxonomy also allows us to see a troubling conflict between the political commitments of the work produced by this social view of writing.

Faigley generally followed James Berlin's lead in organizing his taxonomy and identified the epistemological assumptions of these theories as their unifying feature (Berlin 165–180). Some theorists make stronger and others make more limited claims, but to all of them, knowledge is socially constructed or legitimized (an important distinction) through language and rhetorical activity. While the theories Faigley identifies as the social view describe the relations among rhetoric, knowledge, and society in similar ways, they have very different political commitments. More specifically, the neo-Marxist movement known as radical pedagogy which Faigley included in his grouping has developed a critical analysis and political agenda that is largely missing from the other branches of his social rhetoric. The studies of scientific and professional writing that emerge from this epistemic tradition are dominated by a research strategy that is descriptive and explanatory, rarely critical. That is, due largely to the research methods and the cultural pluralism we have inherited from anthropology, this research lends itself to a mode of reporting that reproduces the dominant discourse of its research site and spends relatively little energy analyzing the modes and possibilities for dissent, resistance, and revision—the very issues that lie at the heart of radical pedagogy.

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On the practical level, the difference in political commitments suggests the problem facing the teacher who cares deeply about her students and is concerned with cultural change, but whose students see writing courses as a way to become successful, productive members of professional communities. Indeed, business and technical writing textbooks often warrant their value to students by citing surveys of writers on the job, documenting the importance of writing for success and promotion. As Patricia Bizzell has phrased it, "our dilemma is that we want to empower students to succeed in the dominant culture so that they can transform it from within; but we fear that if they do succeed, their thinking will be changed in such a way that they will no longer want to transform it" (Bizzell, "Context" 7). The theoretical question suggested by this conflict—and it is especially urgent for researchers and teachers of professional and non-academic writing—is the relation of discourse and teaching to ideological and cultural production.

I am not condemning research and teaching in professional writing; rather, I am making the claim that this research and pedagogical practice do not go far enough. If we recognize and explore the challenge presented by the relationship between discourse, teaching, and social reproduction, we may be able to discover ways to intervene and initiate cultural critique within our research and pedagogical practice. This would, of course, require that we expand our research goals and significantly alter our teaching. If we are uncritical in our research and teaching, however, we contribute to the tyranny of the "real"; our pedagogical practice will produce students who are ignorant of the ideological development of discourse and who cannot perceive the cultural consequences of a dominant discourse or the alternate understandings it excludes.

Teaching and Theories of Cultural Agency

Despite the growing influence of social rhetorics, there has been very little exchange between the two strains represented by radical pedagogy and the social and ethnographic study of science and professional writing. There has been a great deal of work in the past few years devoted to the social and political nature of writing. Little of this work, however, addresses the problem facing those of us in advanced and professional writing who recognize the need for the kind of cultural criticism that acknowledges the political and ideological function of professional discourse. Most of the research in professional writing and disciplinary discourse emerges from the work in ethnography and the social study of science that Faigley located within the social view of rhetoric. This research examines the rhetorical practices of professionals for whom writing is a primary form of their professional work and develops the theory described much earlier by Robert Scott and Michael Leff that rhetoric is epistemic. The thrust of this research is to describe the relationship between written discourse and the professional, organizational, or disciplinary communities established by discourse, which in turn give that discourse meaning and legitimacy (Harrison).

Researchers examine the way discourse helps establish and solidify the organizational identity (Bazerman "Physicists" and "Natural Philosophers"; Paradis, Dobrin, and Miller; Doheny-Farina "Writing" and "Creating"), the way groups differ from each other in the subjects and kinds of arguments they make (Miller and Selzer; Herndl, Fennell, and Miller), the way novices join the group through participating in its discourse (Berkenkotter, Huckin, and Ackerman "Conversations" and "Social Context"; McCarthy "Stranger"; Myers "Social Construction"), and the way they collectively negotiate and authorize knowledge claims (Myers "Texts"; Bazerman "Modern").

There are a number of problems with the limited, descriptive focus of research in professional writing. Among them is the fact that research describes the production of meaning but not the social, political and economic sources of power which authorize this production or the cultural work such discourse performs. As Bizzell has pointed out, studies sometimes suffer a "methodological incapacity for eliciting the ideological" ("Review" 486). If studies do discuss social power, they rarely analyze it; it exists, but its sources and genealogies remain hidden and mystified.

For the work in radical pedagogy that Faigley included in the social view of rhetoric, any analysis of writing is dangerously incomplete without some ideological and cultural analysis. The radical pedagogy shares the assumption of social rhetoric that discourse is epistemic, but concentrates on the politics of institutionalized education and the way it regulates social behavior. Working from Marxist theories of culture, this movement addresses not simply the way knowledge is socially constructed but also the way education reproduces the social order in which that knowledge bears cultural power and underwrites the credentials which legitimize our social hierarchy.

The most familiar source of radical pedagogy for writing theory is the work of Paulo Freire and those who have explained and expanded his critical agenda. Freire's fundamental assumptions are that to be human is to develop a conscious recognition of your relationship to the social world and that education can transform this relationship. To be oppressed in Freire's theory is not only to have your economic and political rights violated, but also to be submerged in what he calls a "culture of silence" by the misrecognition of your relation to the social and ideological. And by "misrecognition" Freire means that you accept the practices and rationalities of your social position as natural and necessary rather than seeing them as ideologically constructed and politically interested. This misrecognition is a form of hegemony that leads people to accept and cooperate with an ideological system which oppresses them.

Working from these assumptions, Freire argues that there is no such thing as neutral education. His ideal, and this is echoed throughout the radical pedagogy, is to bring students to the point of cultural self-consciousness in which they neither accommodate nor merely oppose the social order—both positions being still circumscribed by the structure—but can actively reposition themselves within it. From this perspective, teaching a non-academic discourse

without a careful cultural analysis reinforces the culture's dominant ideological structures and makes cultural self-consciousness difficult if not impossible.

Despite their recognition of the ways schools can maintain and naturalize the ideological structuration of society, few contemporary theorists in radical pedagogy hold the simple view that dominant economic or ideological structures determine schooling. Education does not merely reproduce existing culture, stamping out properly trained employees and managers. Arguing that the school as a cultural institution *produces* culture, these theorists accept the constraining power of ideology, but they also insist on the possibility of change; they see cultural institutions like the school as sites of contestation and struggle as well as domination (Giroux). Radical pedagogy is committed to transformation in education and society, and that requires a "logic of the possible" and a more subtle view of the relationship between cultural domination and schooling (Simon, 385). The key element of this position for writing theory is the notion of resistance which figures so prominently in recent articles on radical pedagogy published in major composition journals (e.g. Paine; Chase; Clifford; Cooper and Selfe).

Theorists have developed the concept of resistance as a reaction against the pessimistic and mechanical model of social reproduction associated with orthodox Marxism which envisions ideology and domination as the homogeneous and all-powerful determinant of culture and institutional practice. For social theorists such as Anthony Giddens and educational theorists such as Henry Giroux these structuralist models have both theoretical and practical limitations. The theory of structure and determination doesn't allow for change and reduces the individual to a function or bearer of structural meaning, thus reducing or even denying the possibility for human agency. In practical terms, these theories often fail to account for the detailed interaction of day-to-day life in classrooms and workplaces. The concept of resistance attempts to fill this gap and connect the constraining power of ideology and institutional practices with possibilities for freedom and liberatory action without reifying either structure or the individual. Thus resistance becomes an essential concept for any pedagogy aimed at political and cultural self-consciousness and liberation.

The most useful conception of resistance comes out of Giddens's work on the theory of "structuration." Giddens argues that the dualism which opposes the individual to the structure should be understood as the "duality of structure." He argues that to progress through our current theoretical stalemate, we need to avoid both the flattened subject who is only a consequence of structure and the voluntarism of the transcendental and self-present individual. In Giddens's theory of "duality," structure does not exist as an atemporal constant set apart or above human action, but is constantly being recreated as the "structural properties" of social practices that are both the "medium and outcome of the practices that constitute those systems" (Giddens 69). In the form of structural properties, structure, like ideology, exists in time and is constantly being generated through a process of struggle and contestation. Thus, Giddens preserves

the power of ideology and structure to constrain action—no agent is free of or prior to these structural properties—but he argues that these structural properties exist only in agents' knowledge or memory of how things are done and in the effects of these properties in the ongoing life of social problems. Giddens describes a dialectical relationship between structure and agency in which each idea entails the other. This dialectical relationship opens the possibility of resistance and change; agents are not subjected to the determination of structure, and their actions effect the structural properties.

In a move very similar to the humanist elements of radical pedagogy, Giddens argues that social actors are not ignorant of the rules and politics of the social practices in which they take part. Social life and the ideological do not operate totally "behind their backs" as strict structuralist positions hold. Agents have both a "practical" knowledge of how things work which remains tacit and an explicit and more limited "discursive" knowledge of social practice which they can articulate. It is in exploring and revealing the practical knowledge and its relations to social power and to the construction of structural properties that Giddens's actors can approach the self-consciousness necessary to critique and liberatory action. Resistance becomes possible when agents recognize the recursive relationship between themselves as social agents and the structural properties of the social practices in which they participate. According to Giddens's theory, agents monitor their action reflexively. This makes it possible to articulate the shape of the structural properties through which they act and to change the conditions of their actions. That is, by recognizing and articulating the medium of their actions, they can affect the outcome of those actions. Thus education becomes a key process for either cultural self-recognition (Freire's *conscientizacao*) or the reification of the structural properties as simply "the way things are" (Freire's "culture of silence").

Together, the idea of cultural (re)production and the theory of resistance present the major political challenge to the work of social or epistemic rhetoric in professional writing research. The problem with the largely descriptive focus of professional writing research from the perspective of the radical pedagogy is that in teaching discourse we may be merely reproducing the social structures, ideologies, and subjectivities of the various communities we study. As we introduce our students to the various professional and organizational discourses we explore in our research, we may be reifying the social relations of which those discourses are a part. As Greg Myers has pointed out, when we take the discourse of the "real world" as the basis of our pedagogy we "perpetuate the idea that reality is something outside us and beyond our efforts to change it" ("Reality" 161).

Once we abandon the current traditional rhetoric's notion of writing as a neutral, apolitical skill, we must recognize that discourse is inseparable from institutions, from organizational structures, from disciplinary and professional knowledge claims and interests, and from the day-to-day interaction of workers. Because discourse is related recursively to social practice and institutions—each

shaping the other—we have to face the fact that in teaching discourse we are unavoidably engaged in the production of professional and cultural power. Fortunately, the nature of this engagement is not determinate.

Connecting Discourse to Material Conditions

In order to investigate the connections between professional writing research and pedagogy and the production of institutional power, we need to understand discourse not just as epistemic and recursively tied to communities, but also as connected to material and institutional practices. Such a theory must tie discourse to the social construction of knowledge, the task of much professional and non-academic writing research, as well as to the ideological and structural properties that condition discourse, the task of the radical pedagogy. We must connect discourse to social and institutional practices so that both we and our students can see how discourse and the reality it constructs are shaped by the political, economic, and material interests of professions and the institutions they create. In this way our students can learn to participate in professional discourse, but also to recognize it as contingent and ideologically interested. If we can identify and explain the way discourse is conditioned by professional practice and the way that discourse has ideological consequences, we can avoid reifying social relations through the “reality” of discourse. Because it can show students the historic or institutional development of the rationality, values, and order entailed in discourse, this position can help students escape the “culture of silence” fostered by an uncritical attitude toward hegemonic discourse.

A theory of discourse adequate to both professional writing research and radical pedagogy should also recognize that no discourse is uniform; all professional, institutional, or disciplinary discourses are crossed by a number of competing interests and positions. Just as ideology emerges through continuing struggle with opposing positions, the discourse through which it is realized is formed through struggle with other discourses, other cultural positions and interests. Similarly, the institutions which are the sites of cultural production always contain multiple and competing interests; cultural and ideological power are not monolithic.

One liability of many descriptions of professional writing is their tendency to focus on the dominant discourse and overlook the discourse of contesting positions (Spellmeyer 720–21). In professional and non-academic writing research this tendency grows out of the need to establish the existence of distinct, situated professional discourses. In order to counter the view of writing as a universal skill with independent standards and norms which held sway in English departments for so long, research in social rhetoric has concentrated on identifying distinct non-academic discourse communities. Unfortunately, this approach has too often blinded us to the differences and the struggles within professional discourses. The consequence is that the discourse we refer to when

we talk about the “discourse of engineering,” etc. is all too often a reification of the dominant position which flattens the discursive and ideological struggles that exist within any social or institutional practice. In describing the hegemonic discourse, we need to remember that hegemony is a process of conflict, always carried out between multiple positions. If we describe these struggles and their different interests and consequences, we can open a space for students to recognize the range of positions negotiated by and sometimes excluded from the dominant discourse. Given such an understanding of discourse, we and our students can explore the possibilities for resistance so necessary for change and self-conscious participation in discourse.

To illustrate how the research in professional writing and social rhetoric might develop this model of discourse and cultural criticism, I would like to look at one recent article on professional writing. In an article on the American Psychiatric Association’s third edition of its *Diagnostic and Statistical Manual of Mental Disorders*, otherwise known as *DSM-III*, Lucille McCarthy describes this document and its influence over the discourse of clinical psychiatrists. McCarthy provides a rhetorical analysis of the way *DSM-III* structures one psychiatrist’s diagnostic work by tracing the epistemological and textual consequences of *DSM-III* on the psychiatrist’s work with one of her patients.

McCarthy describes the way the discourse established by *DSM-III* constructs the psychiatrist’s knowledge by determining what counts as data and how it is analyzed, as well as how the discourse organizes psychiatric practice and coordinates communication between colleagues. By dictating the sources of information, the categories in which to place clinical observations, and the amount of clinical data required for a diagnosis, *DSM-III* provides the source of authority and persuasion for the doctor’s diagnosis. The diagnosis is essentially an argument, and *DSM-III* functions rhetorically as the set of warrants which underwrite doctors’ diagnostic claims. The analysis of the data and the recommendation for treatment are warranted by the criteria and the format presented in the manual in a similar way. *DSM-III* crystallizes the kinds of epistemic assumptions that always function in professional discourse, although usually without the clarity and ubiquity of this case.

I choose to discuss McCarthy’s article because it also provides evidence of the connections between this discourse and the material and institutional practices that shape *DSM-III* and, thereby, the psychiatric discourse and its reality. While it is not the focus of her analysis, McCarthy’s discussion provides evidence of the ideological construction of psychiatric discourse and its recursive relation to the “structural properties” of institutional medicine. Her analysis also offers some evidence of resistant positions and the process of ideological hegemony. It is these last two issues, the ideological construction and the existence of dissenting discourse, that seem most useful to me in the current context. These issues are only latent in McCarthy’s analysis of *DSM-III*; McCarthy’s is an excellent analysis, but, as with the vast majority of research in professional writing, questions of ideology and resistance are not central to her project. Her essay

does, however, suggest ways that we might expand our research agenda to include the ideological.

Beyond demonstrating the epistemic nature of *DSM-III* and its discourse, McCarthy's analysis moves us closer to the radical pedagogy's notion that discourse can reify political and economic relations under the name of science or truth. While it was not one of the stated purposes of the manual, the publication of *DSM-III* effectively institutionalized the "biomedical model" of mental illness to the detriment of the competing "interpretive model." The biomedical model is the familiar model of disease that dominates the American Medical Association. It is based on the theory of "specific etiology," that is, the idea that disease is caused by a specific biological factor that can be cured using specific drugs. Biomedical psychiatry acknowledges that there may be multiple and interacting factors that call for integrated treatment, but its focus is empirical and its method describes objectively-defined biological and clinical features.

The competing interpretive model, as McCarthy explains, is developed from the work of Freud, Adler, and Jung and regards the patient's illness as the symptom of some conflict within the unconscious. The focus here is less on taxonomizing symptoms than on intervening in the disorder by constructing an interpretation of the symptoms that is a therapeutic story of the patient's life. To the interpretive model, the patient is an individual with a story to tell. To the biomedical model, she is a member of a group with impairments to be explained (362).

Much more is at stake here than merely the efficient operation of the clinic. The one model presents itself as objective and empirical, based on the profession's powerful taxonomy and diagnostic criteria. In deploying this apparatus, however, this model appropriates the patient's story and voice, effectively reducing both the patient and the psychiatrist to subjects of diagnostic structure. Diagnosis is something to be done as quickly as possible, and both the patient and the psychiatrist are carefully restricted in what they can discuss, in what counts as relevant data. A whole range of concerns and professional relations are denied the doctor and her patient by the institutional subjectivity. The competing interpretive model recognizes the patient's integrity and allows her to interact with the discipline to construct an interpretation of her symptoms and, thus, a representation of her self. Implicit in these two models are quite different theories of subjectivity and of the subject's relationship to power. Furthermore, only one of these models is legitimized by the dominant professional discourse of psychiatry. This arrangement clearly demonstrates the relation of knowledge to power and the politics of medical practice. It is a discourse that reifies the practitioner's technical mastery of the field and alienates the patient from her own disease.

McCarthy's study also demonstrates the way the rhetorical features that legitimize and warrant knowledge claims are connected to the material conditions within society which interact with the discourse. The need for diagnostic standards was precipitated by the advent of psychoactive drugs in the 1950s.

Because the drugs had specific and predictable effects, their presence helped foster a model for specific biological causes of mental illness. Far from being organized around the search for abstract truth, this discourse is a practical response to a specific material condition—powerful new drugs, access to which was restricted to those holding medical degrees.

The profession's need for reliability and universal standards was also conditioned by the requirements of the insurance industry and the courts. If we pursued the issue, we might find that the notion of a taxonomy of diseases and the standardizing of diagnosis were instigated not by scientific objectivity, but by the medical reimbursement forms and the cost accounting of medical insurance firms. The interpretive model which *DSM-III* rejects is less concerned with taxonomizing disorders; by contrast to the biomedical model, it concentrates on explaining the etiology of mental disorders and less on precise diagnosis. The authority of diagnoses based on *DSM-III* and the standards for reliable diagnosis which McCarthy describes are as likely to arise out of the legal protection offered to practitioners by recognized standards for diagnosis and analysis as from any independent "scientific" requirements. Thus we can begin to see the way in which this discourse and its knowledge are contingent, not just on the incomplete nature of clinical research as the profession acknowledges, but also on the economic, legal, and accounting practices which organize the clinic and its discourse. In other words, institutional and economic interests contribute to the formation of the discourse and its definition of clinical reality.

Finally, this example suggests the self-legitimizing function of institutional discourse, what Pierre Bourdieu and Jean Claude Passeron have called the institutionalized "pedagogic action" (5–11). One of the American Psychiatric Association's explicit purposes in writing *DSM-III*, you will recall, was to increase communication within the profession. Since 1980 when *DSM-III* was published, there has been an explosion of research articles which, guided by the manual, have extended and modified the clinical model. The manual recorded the practice of psychiatrists selected on the basis of their clinical experience and publication, and its publication generated huge new amounts of clinical work. As McCarthy points out, "some 2000 articles were published between 1980 and 1987 reporting research that used or directly investigated the manual's diagnostic categories and criteria" (375). These texts further legitimize and naturalize the discourse and its institutional power; these articles form the basis of textbooks and clinical training, "further increasing the web of this discourse system" (376), and, we might add, the ideological construction of illness, power, and institutional control over the body. If we recall here Geoffrey Chase's observation that discourse privileges certain ideologically interested practices at the expense of others, we can see the education of new clinicians and their initiation into this discourse as the production of an ideological position and its institutional forms.

The discourse generated by *DSM-III* certainly dominates psychiatric practice, but it is not uncontested. As McCarthy points out, this discourse is highly

selective, and her informant recognizes its power to occlude alternate forms of knowledge and interaction. The psychiatrist describes a hypothetical case in which a client says that her husband just committed suicide and *DSM-III* forces the doctor to move on to the next diagnostic question—Where do you work?—without responding. We can see the psychiatrist's resistance in her frustration at the narrowness and power of the professional discourse. The discourse is also disrupted by the presence of the competing interpretive model, with its different definition of disorder and very different pattern of interaction. Despite the presence of *DSM-III*, some psychiatrists continue to use the interpretive model. In doing so, they introduce a different model of subjectivity and control in which the patient maintains substantial autonomy.

The extent to which psychiatrists can diverge from the standards and procedures established by *DSM-III* is not clear. Nor is it clear how such resistance would change treatment within large clinics, or what alternate forms of discourse are available. But it is clear that some practitioners are aware of the coercive power of the discourse and that some occupy opposing positions from which contesting discourse can emerge. Because McCarthy's task is to describe the way *DSM-III* influences psychiatric discourse, the moments and modes of opposition and resistance fall largely outside her purview. In describing the power of the charter document and the practice it privileges, McCarthy does not explore alternate discourses, different forms of reporting or communication, or the ways the interpretive model of illness continues to enter psychiatric discourse.

For a theory of discourse concerned with cultural production, however, these oppositional positions and practices are extremely important. McCarthy's analysis provides enough information to begin the political analysis of discourse and its cultural consequences demanded by radical pedagogy. But to explore adequately the cultural construction of psychiatric discourse and the consequences for our experience of mental illness and the body, we need to widen the scope of our research to include the political and ideological. We need research that explores the material conditions of professional psychiatry and the way the licensing and credentialing process produces doctors ignorant of competing medical and cultural models.

In order to provide a description of discourse adequate to the theory of resistance, we also need research that explores conflict and dissenting positions as necessary and valuable. Some research in professional writing examines dissent and conflict within professional discourse, but usually as a source of failure and the breakdown of effective communication (Doheny-Farina "Creating"; Herndl, Fennell, and Miller). Careful ethnographic research might use techniques such as the discourse-based interview to explore an individual agent's relationship to the dominant discourse. Such discourse-based research might begin by exploring the degree to which individual agents understand the institutional and ideological construction of their discourse. By examining what Giddens calls an agent's discursive and practical knowledge of the structural

properties, which are both the “medium and outcome” (69) of their discourse, researchers may discover a fine texture of alternatives and resistance within existing discourses.

The Problems of Confrontational Classrooms

The theoretical problem that radical pedagogy presents to advanced and professional writing suggests that we need to reinterpret much of our existing research and expand our research agenda to investigate the ideological and the existence of resistance. Articles like McCarthy’s point the way to these possibilities, but it is not yet clear how this theoretical position or expanded research would affect pedagogy. Teachers who attempt to address questions of ideology and resistance in advanced and professional writing courses face a number of difficult problems. Theories of resistance and ideology are all too often dogmatic and structure the course as a confrontation between oversimplified positions. Teachers also face the fact that not only are the ideas of resistance and the ideological construction of discourse very difficult for students, the notion of critique threatens their cultural position, their values, their desires and expectations.

As Susan Wells has argued, the rhetoric of technical and professional discourse is designed to achieve what Habermas calls purposive rational action; it is a discourse aimed at resolving technical and organizational problems. Given this rhetoric and purpose, a pedagogy which only exposes a hidden ideological structure of interest and domination would be inappropriate for technical and professional discourse (247). Furthermore, a pedagogy which sets up a stark confrontation between the repressive ideology of the dominant discourse and the teacher’s emancipatory ideology structures the classroom as an opposition between the teacher and the students. Not only does such an opposition ignore the struggles and the differences within discourse, even within the dominant professional discourse, it establishes a classroom politics that restricts the cooperation and dialogue so central to radical pedagogy. The more this opposition structures the classroom, the less chance the students have of exploring their own discourse and cultural position. Ironically, students will become once again the objects of what Freire calls the banking model of education, the objects this time of the teacher’s ideological enlightenment. Since critique generally subverts the dominant ideology and this is the position typically occupied by students in professional writing courses, a confrontational pedagogy is more likely to produce opposition among the students than to encourage cultural resistance.

If we return briefly to Giddens’s theory of structuration and the knowledge of social practices which agents possess, we can outline a pedagogy for professional writing courses. The difficulty, of course, lies in getting students to recognize the connections between discourse and structural properties, and, further, to see how this relationship conditions their rhetorical choices. Rather than pose this relationship as a theoretical one as I have here, however, teachers

need to begin by working with a discourse and institution which is palpable to the students. Raymond Williams has remarked that no one becomes a Marxist for theoretical reasons, but only as a result of economic and political experience (2). Similarly, students will best recognize the connections between ideology, power, and discourse, and the value of resistance, if teachers begin with a discourse that directly impinges on student's lives. Like the agents in Giddens's theory, students have some understanding of the political and ideological structures within which they write as students. By the time they reach advanced and professional writing courses, these students have a good sense of the politics of university classrooms. The structural properties of the university do not operate wholly behind their backs. Because they rarely articulate this understanding, however, their discursive knowledge of these properties is relatively limited, but they do have considerable practical or tacit understanding of these structural properties and their relation to discourse. In Giddens's terms, students can achieve a level of resistance and discursive self-awareness by articulating their practical knowledge of academic discourse. If they understand the ideological and institutional conditions within which they work, they will be more aware of the rhetorical situations within which they write and can become self-reflexive agents within the university.

One way to organize this pedagogy which provides an analogy for introducing professional discourse is to adapt the understanding of "dissensus" that John Trimbur has articulated for collaborative learning. John Trimbur has argued that collaborative learning can develop a "rhetoric of dissensus" which leads students not to a conformity which reifies the existing social and institutional relations, but rather to "collective explanations of how people differ, where the differences come from, and whether they can live and work together with these differences" (610). Because he is interested in using collaborative learning to transform the students' relations to the discourses in which they participate, Trimbur understands discourse as a struggle between opposing positions and sees the consensus of the classroom "as an oppositional one that challenges the prevailing conditions of production" (612). Once students in professional writing courses have come to understand the relations between discourse and Trimbur's conditions of production, what Giddens calls structural properties, teachers can use this understanding to introduce professional discourse. Certainly, professional discourses are crossed by different ideological conflicts, different institutional and material conditions, than those operating within the university. But the nature of structural properties and their relation to discourse is not fundamentally different for professional and non-academic discourses. Once students see how these issues apply to their academic discourse, they can begin to apply the same understanding to the professional discourses they are entering. This rhetoric of dissensus does not condemn professional or technical discourse as ideologically incorrect, but it does allow students to recognize the ideological conditions and consequences of these discourses, and it provides a practical model of resistance.

It is at this point that a reinterpreted and expanded body of research in professional and technical discourse will be essential. Students will not be able to make the leap from discussing the discourse of the university to analyzing the professional discourses they are entering without the aid of this research. Articles like McCarthy's will not apply directly to every student's curriculum and professional discourse. The biochemistry student who plans research on gene splicing, the industrial engineer planning to do production analyses, and the computer engineer working on software application are all entering substantially different professional discourses. Despite this, research that explores the relations between specific discourses and structural properties can provide students and teachers a place to start in learning these new discourses. Unfortunately, there are only a limited number of research reports like McCarthy's that can offer us a place to begin. This pedagogy demands not only work to reinterpret the research we have, but new research to investigate the ideological work and the struggles that occur within professional discourse. Working from such reinterpreted and reconceived research, students and teachers can begin to explore the sources of power and authority which condition their disciplinary and professional discourse. When it is successful, this pedagogy will allow students to participate in these professional discourses with a degree of self-reflexivity and ideological awareness necessary to resistance and cultural criticism.

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